

UNDERCOVER

A Tale of Mon-eater Monitors

DVD rips and 3D games wouldn't be as much fun without the right monitor. Agent 001 is on the lookout for the best you can feast your eyes on



"17-inch monitors are distinctly cheaper now than a year back...while 14-inch monitors are going out of fashion"

As I sat watching *Indiana Jones and the Temple of Doom* on my 14-inch monitor, I was taken over by an overpowering urge, an urge so strong that throughout the movie all I could think was: I need a new monitor! So for my next mission I went in search of a spanking new monitor.

Most people buy a monitor according to the overall budget of their system. The monitor is undoubtedly one of the most expensive components in the system configuration, but at the same time it has a longer life than most other components, better build quality, and usually lives up to what it promises.

With the overall prices of budget systems falling to almost Rs 30,000 and below, 17-inch monitors seem a possible choice for many. A local vendor in Andheri (E) confirmed this, saying that there has been a distinct move towards 17-inch monitors in the market and manufacturers were concentrating more on this segment. He observed that these monitors are significantly cheaper now than a year back—as low as Rs 11,000—and added that the Samsung SyncMaster 750s was doing especially well. Most people generally start off by asking for a flat screen 17-inch monitor but in the end settle down for a cheaper one due to the high price, said the dealer.

Another vendor in the same area said that people mostly buy 15 or 17-inch monitors, with the 14-inch going completely out of fashion. Due

to the low price difference between 14-inch and 15-inch monitors, the latter have been selling well too, said the dealer. However, this difference is significant between 15 and 17-inch monitors (around Rs 3,000). When asked about a specific difference between various brands in terms of performance, he was at a loss of words, but mentioned candidly that on most occasions the monitor box is not even opened nor checked! He was vague in numbers too. "It varies from month to month, but it's generally higher during the rainy season due to the increased humidity," was his answer about the approximate number of monitors he gets to repair in a month.

According to another vendor, while flat monitors were still out of range of most first-time buyers, the LG Flatron 775FT is the most sought-after flat monitor in the 17-inch category. He added wistfully that the more expensive Sony monitors were usually bought by design professionals, and that he hadn't sold a single one yet.

Moving on further south, a vendor said that people generally come with a distinct brand preference, so much so that certain users will not buy anything but a specific model. He had no preferences himself as such, except for the ViewSonic E53 for its 15-inch range and the 17-inch Samsung SyncMaster series.

A more technically proficient vendor at Lamington Road said that buyers rarely look beyond size in spite of the products being technically complex. Most users have distinct brand awareness when it comes to monitors, but nothing much beyond that, was his opinion. "Most users come for Samsung monitors, while others don't tolerate anything but a ViewSonic".

Vendor two in Lamington said that as far as statistics go, SyncMaster sings, and that too with minimal problems. Vendor three faced small nagging problems such as buttons and knobs not working in cheaper monitors and non-functioning tubes, brightness and contrast errors in bigger ones. Vendor three was clear about his choice though: SyncMaster 955DF in the flatter variety and the LG Studioworks 995E for the three-year warranty.

As for me, I know what to watch *Indiana Jones* again on! 📺

A Monitor's Video Bandwidth

The video bandwidth of a monitor is nothing but an indication of its ability to refresh the screen fast enough. This bandwidth is calculated by multiplying horizontal and vertical resolution by the maximum vertical refresh the monitor can be run at on that resolution: for example, a monitor that can be operated at 800x600 at a maximum of 85 Hz will have a video bandwidth of 40.8 MHz (800x600x85). Therefore, we see that since the video bandwidth is a constant for a given monitor, the higher the resolution you run the monitor at, the lower will be

the vertical refresh rate it will be able to run at.

Even though monitors might have the same screen size (15, 17, 19-inch, etc), they could have different video bandwidths. Usually, the more expensive monitors within a given range will feature a higher bandwidth as they will support higher resolutions and refresh rates. As a rule of thumb, if you're looking for the best monitor of a given screen size, buy the one that supports the highest video bandwidth as you'll be able to run it at higher resolutions and refresh rates.

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